



The Raspberry Pi Glossary

Word	Explanation
APT	Advanced Packaging Tool. The software manager used on Raspberry Pi to install updates and new applications.
ARM	A low-cost and minimal power consumption architecture for computer processors, used on all the Raspberry Pi models.
CLI	Command Line Interface. The black screen where we can only use Linux commands to interact with the operating system.
CPU	Central Processing Unit. Basically, the processor, the primary component of a computer to run everything.
DHCP	Dynamic Host Configuration Protocol. Networking service which automatically assign an IP address to each new device on the network.
Distribution	A Linux operating system version, using a specific set of software. Ex: Raspberry Pi OS, Ubuntu, Debian.
DNS	Domain Name System. A system or service which translates domain names to IP addresses, the only identifier understood by computers.
Etcher	Balena Etcher is a tool to copy the operating system files on a specific device (in general: USB or SD card).
Ethernet	Networking technology. Generally used to identify the wired connection or port on a Raspberry Pi.
Firmware	The basic software controlling the low-level operations for a specific hardware.
Flash	The action to copy the operating system files to a SD card with Etcher, Raspberry Pi Imager or similar tools. A Flash memory is reprogrammable and retains the programmed data.
GPIO	General Purpose Input Output. The Raspberry Pi include a 40 GPIO pins on each board, to create an electronic circuit and use extension cards (HAT).
GPU	Graphic Processing Unit. The equivalent of the CPU to handle all the graphical part (display, video processing, etc).
GUI	Graphical User Interface. A CLI with graphics. Mouse and graphical tools are available to make device management easier.
HAT	Hardware Attached on Top. Extension cards that can be plugged on the GPIO pins of a Raspberry Pi.
HDMI	High-Definition Multimedia Interface. The main display interface on Raspberry Pi. Recent models are using different variants (Mini or Micro-HDMI ports).



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Headless	A term used to define the use of a Raspberry Pi without any screens.
Hostname	A name assigned to a device on a network.
I2C	Inter Integrated Circuit. Several GPIO pins are reserved for I2C devices. It's a specific bus to connect compatible peripherals.
IP Address	Unique identifier for a device on a network. Ex: 192.168.1.10
LAN	Local Area Network. Generally refers to your network at home. Opposite to a WAN (Wide Area Network) that we use to speak about the Internet.
LibreOffice	A complete office suite, including a word processor and spreadsheet (free alternative to Microsoft Office)
Linux	A family of open-source operating system using the Linux kernel, the base of all the Linux distributions.
MAC Address	Media Access Control Address. A unique identifier assigned to each network card. Can be used in a DHCP server to reserve an IP address to each device.
NOOBS	New Out-Of-the-Box Software. It was the basic software pre-installed on most SD cards for Raspberry Pi to install an operating system. Obsolete, no longer developed.
OS	Operating System. A software application that manages everything on a computer (hardware, resources, software, services). Ex: Windows, macOS, Linux.
Partition	One segment of a storage device (hard drive or SD card) that we allocate to a specific usage. Ex: / and /boot are the main partitions on a Raspberry Pi.
PIXEL	A desktop environment, based on LXDE and adapted for the Raspberry Pi. Now referred as "Raspberry Pi Desktop".
Python	A popular programming language, pre-installed on Raspberry Pi OS.
RAM	Random Access Memory. A temporary and fast storage type present on any computer. In general, the more RAM you have, the faster your programs will run. It's also better to use several apps simultaneously.
Raspberry Pi OS	A Linux distribution especially tailored for the Raspberry Pi. It's the default operating system, based on Debian.
Raspbian	Obsolete. The name of the default Linux distribution before Raspberry Pi OS (same thing, they only changed the name).
Raspi-config	A tool available on Raspberry Pi OS to configure the system from a terminal.
Repository	A server or group of servers on the Internet hosting the software files used by the package manager. Each Linux distribution have several repositories.



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root	The name of the administrator account on Linux systems.
Scratch	A visual programming language and tool. Pre-installed on Raspberry Pi OS with Desktop, and intended to help kids to learn how to code without the hassle of the programming syntax.
SD card	Secure Digital card. The main storage device on Raspberry Pi (microSD card in fact).
SPI	Serial Peripheral Interface bus. Similar to I2C, another way to communicate with compatible peripherals via some GPIO pins.
Splash screen	The image or graphical element displayed on boot by most operating systems. Can also refer to the same thing for an application (Ex: Gimp, PyCharm and Photoshop have a splash screen).
SSD	Solid-State Drive. A storage device, faster than the usual HDD, and also the SD cards. Can be used as the main storage on recent Raspberry Pi models (instead of the SD card).
SSH	Secure Shell Protocol. A network protocol used to remotely access a computer (a Raspberry Pi for example). This enables access to the Raspberry Pi terminal from another device.
sudo	Stands for "super user do!". Allow us to run commands with administrator privileges from an authorized user session. Ex: the "pi" user can use sudo instead of switching to "root".
Underscan	A setting enabling automatic adjustment of the display to the screen size. Disable it if you have black bars that appear on the sides of your screen. Opposite: overscan.
VNC	Virtual Network Computing. A software application for remote access, pre-installed on Raspberry Pi OS. It allows us to control the Raspberry Pi desktop environment from another computer.



Want to go further?

This glossary is just the start. Inside the Raspberry Pi Bootcamp, you'll learn everything about your Raspberry Pi: how to install the OS, build cool projects, and actually enjoy the process.

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